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The Eyes Have it

Divas whose souls lit up the screen like flickering diyas...



INDIA PICTURE



Nutan

Her delicate face, half-hidden in the folds of her saree, turned away as her lover walks away—Nutan was eternal in the eponymous role in *Sujata* (1959), a woman struggling for identity against a brutal caste system. The role that defined her as an actress; we saw her vulnerability, the quiet ache of a girl seeking acceptance. She mined that delicate vein of silver in *Seema* (1955) and *Bandini* (1963), but there was also playfulness in *Tere Ghar Ke Samne* (1863), as she skipped down the Qutub Minar's steps with Dev Anand, singing about the hum in their hearts. That blend of softness and steel flowed into a variety of roles over four decades, that unforgettable sweetness of her smile lighting up the screen even amidst the greys of life.

Smita Patil

She played many incandescent roles in a short-lived career, but two stood out—both where she played, ironically, actresses. In Shyam Benegal's *Bhumika* (1977), she was Usha, struggling to find her identity through abuse and emotional upheaval, succeeding as a star even as the men around her exploit and stifle her. In *Arth* (1982), she was the highly-strung, mentally fragile Kavita, in an affair with her much-married director. Smita interplays the high-voltage scenes with her contemporary Shabana Azmi beautifully—the 'other woman' so haunted by the ghost of 'the wife'. Emotions chased across her face in films from across genres, whether *Manthan* (1976), or as she let her hair down and captured joyfulness and sensuality in *Namak Halaal* (1982). The image that stays with you, perhaps fittingly, is from her last year: the sheer rebelliousness as she hurls chillies in the face of her tormentor (*Mirch Masala*, 1986).

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